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AI



Mira Murati's Thinking
Machines Lab is worth
\$12B in seed round

A woman with long brown hair, Mira Murati, is speaking and gesturing with her hands. The background is dark with out-of-focus yellow lights.

Thinking Machines Lab, the AI startup founded by OpenAI's former chief technology officer Mira Murati, officially closed a \$2 billion seed round led by Andreessen Horowitz on Monday, a company spokesperson told TechCrunch.

The deal, which includes participation from Nvidia, Accel, ServiceNow, CISCO, AMD, and Jane Street, values the startup at \$12 billion, the spokesperson said.

Several outlets reported in June that Thinking Machines Lab was close to closing this \$2 billion funding round at a \$10 billion valuation, but,

apparently, that valuation has shot up in the last month.

The deal marks one of the largest seed rounds — or first funding rounds — in Silicon Valley history, representing the massive investor appetite to back promising new AI labs. Thinking Machines Lab is less than a year old and has yet to reveal what it's working on.

However, Murati peeled back the curtain on the company's first product a bit in a post on X Tuesday, claiming that the startup plans to unveil its work in the “next couple months,” and it will include a “significant open source offering.” Murati also said the product will be useful for researchers and startups building custom AI models.

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“Soon, we’ll also share our best science to help the research community better understand frontier AI systems,” said Murati.



Mira Murati 
@miramurati · [Follow](#)



Thinking Machines Lab exists to empower humanity through advancing collaborative general intelligence.

We're building multimodal AI that works with how you naturally interact with the world - through conversation, through sight, through the messy way we collaborate. We're [Show more](#)

4:59 PM · Jul 15, 2025



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It’s unclear if Murati means that Thinking Machines Lab will release an open AI model, as some of OpenAI’s other competitors have done to undercut the ChatGPT maker’s offerings. A Thinking Machines Lab spokesperson declined to comment further.

Since Murati launched her venture, Thinking Machines Lab has attracted some of her former co-workers at OpenAI, including John Schulman, Barret Zoph, and Luke Metz. Murati says her company is currently trying to staff up, specifically for people with a track record of “building successful AI-driven products from the ground up,” according to the [startup’s website](#).

Meta reportedly held [talks to acquire Thinking Machines Lab](#) in recent months to bolster its superintelligence efforts, but they didn’t progress to a final offer.

Thinking Machines Lab is one of a handful of AI startups that investors believe to be a legitimate

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threat to leading AI model developers today, such as OpenAI, Anthropic, and Google DeepMind.

With billions in funding, Murati may have enough of a war chest to train frontier AI models. Thinking Machines Lab previously [struck a deal with Google Cloud](#) to power its AI models.

Surely, Thinking Machines Lab has an uphill battle to catch up with other AI labs. It's likely banking on novel research breakthroughs to set it apart; however, that's an increasingly difficult task as Meta, Google DeepMind, Anthropic, and OpenAI invest billions in their own research teams.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI Lab](#) [OpenAI](#)



Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter | [X](#)

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

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Thinking Machines Lab is ex-OpenAI CTO Mira Murati's new startup

Kyle Wiggers — 10:30 AM PST · February 18, 2025

Former OpenAI CTO Mira Murati has announced her new startup. Unsurprisingly, it's focused on AI.

Called [Thinking Machines Lab](#), the startup, which came out of stealth today, intends to build tooling to “make AI work for [people’s] unique needs and goals,” and to create AI systems that are “more widely understood, customizable, and generally capable” than those currently available.

Murati is heading up Thinking Machines Lab as CEO. [OpenAI co-founder John Schulman](#) is the company’s chief scientist, and [Barret Zoph](#), who led model post-training at OpenAI, is the CTO.

In a blog post shared with TechCrunch, Thinking Machines Lab wrote that while AI capabilities have advanced dramatically, “key gaps” remain.

“The scientific community’s understanding of frontier AI systems lags behind rapidly advancing capabilities,” the blog post reads. “Knowledge of how these systems are trained is concentrated within the top research labs, limiting both the public

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discourse on AI and people’s abilities to use AI effectively. And, despite their potential, these systems remain difficult for people to customize to their specific needs and values.”

Thinking Machines Lab plans to focus on building “multimodal” systems that “work with people collaboratively,” according to the blog post, and that can “adapt to the full spectrum of human expertise and enable a broader spectrum” of applications.

“[W]e are building models at the frontier of capabilities in domains like science and programming,” the blog post stated. “Ultimately, the most advanced models will unlock the most transformative applications and benefits, such as enabling novel scientific discoveries and engineering breakthroughs.”

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AI safety will be another core tenet of Thinking Machines Lab's work. The company said that it plans to contribute to safety by preventing misuse of the models it releases, sharing best practices and recipes for how to build safe AI systems with the industry, and supporting external research on alignment by sharing code, datasets, and model specifications.

"We'll focus on understanding how our systems create genuine value in the real world," Thinking Machines Lab wrote in its blog post. "The most important breakthroughs often come from rethinking our objectives, not just optimizing existing metrics."

I started Thinking Machines Lab alongside a remarkable team of scientists, engineers, and builders. We're building three things:

- Helping people adapt AI systems to work for their specific needs
- Developing strong foundations to build more capable AI systems
- Fostering a...

— Mira Murati (@miramurati) [February 18, 2025](#)

[Murati left OpenAI last October after six years at the company.](#) At the time, she said she was stepping away to "do her own exploration."

Murati came to OpenAI in 2018 as VP of applied AI and partnerships. After being promoted to CTO in 2022, she led the company's work on [ChatGPT](#), the

text-to-image AI [DALL-E](#), and the code-generating system [Codex](#), which powered early versions of [GitHub's Copilot](#) programming assistant.

Mirati was briefly OpenAI's interim CEO after CEO Sam Altman's [abrupt firing](#). Altman has described her as a close ally.

For months, rumors have flown of Murati hiring high-profile AI researchers and staffers for an AI venture. Thinking Machines Lab's blog lists 29 employees from OpenAI, Character AI, and Google DeepMind, among other top firms.

Thinking Machines Lab is actively hiring machine learning scientists and engineers, as well as a research program manager, per the company's post.

At one point, Murati was said to be in talks to raise over \$100 million from unnamed VC firms. The blog didn't confirm or deny this.

Before OpenAI, Murati spent three years at Tesla as a senior product manager of the Model X, the automaker's crossover SUV, during which Tesla released early versions of Autopilot, its AI-enabled driver-assistance software. She also was VP of product and engineering at [Leap Motion](#), a startup building hand- and finger-tracking motion sensors for PCs.

Murati joins a growing list of former OpenAI execs launching startups, including rivals such as [Ilya Sutskever's Safe Superintelligence](#) and Anthropic.

Topics: [AI](#) [Mira Murati](#) [Startups](#)

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Kyle Wiggers

AI Editor | X reddit @ in

Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch’s AI Editor until June 2025.
His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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OpenAI CTO Mira Murati says she’s leaving the company

Maxwell Zeff, Kyle Wiggers

12:15 PM PDT · September 25, 2024

OpenAI’s [CTO Mira Murati](#) posted on X on [Wednesday](#) saying she is leaving the company.

Murati said she is stepping away to do her own exploration after more than six years at the AI startup.

“After much reflection, I have made the difficult decision to leave OpenAI,” she said in the post. “There’s never an ideal time to step away from a place one cherishes, yet this moment feels right ... My six-and-a-half years with the OpenAI team have been an extraordinary privilege.”

An OpenAI spokesperson declined to comment further, directing TechCrunch to Murati’s tweet.

CEO Sam Altman responded to Murati’s tweet by thanking her in another [post](#). “We’ll say more about the transition plans soon, but for now, I want to take a moment to just feel thanks,” said Altman. “I feel tremendous gratitude towards her for what she has helped us build and accomplish, but I most of all feel personal gratitude towards her for the support and love during all the hard times.”

I replied with this. Mira, thank you for everything.

It’s hard to overstate how much Mira has meant to OpenAI, our mission, and to us all personally.

I feel tremendous gratitude towards her for what she has helped us build and accomplish, but I most of all feel personal...

— Sam Altman (@sama) [September 25, 2024](#)

The decision comes just a week before OpenAI’s [DevDay](#), its annual developer conference.

When Altman was abruptly fired late last year by OpenAI’s previous board of directors, [the board briefly installed Murati as interim CEO](#). Murati was [reportedly](#) among those, along with ex-OpenAI chief scientist [Ilya Sutskever](#), who approached the

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rest of the board prior to Altman's ouster to express concerns about his behavior.

Altman is increasingly asserting control over OpenAI and its image.

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[On Monday, Altman penned a blog post saying](#), among other hyperboles, that OpenAI could achieve "superintelligence" in the next few years. He's also [reportedly](#) poised to receive equity in OpenAI for the first time as the company prepares

to move away from its nonprofit governance structure.

Murati came to OpenAI in 2018 as VP of applied AI and partnerships. After being promoted to CTO in 2022, she led the company's work on the viral AI-powered chatbot [ChatGPT](#), the text-to-image AI [DALL-E](#), and the code-generating system [Codex](#), which powers [GitHub's Copilot](#) product.

She has a degree in mechanical engineering from Dartmouth College and previously worked as an intern at Goldman Sachs and then at Zodiac Aerospace, the French aerospace group. She spent three years at Tesla as a senior product manager of the Model X, the automaker's crossover SUV, during which Tesla released early versions of Autopilot, its AI-enabled driver-assistance software.

In 2016, Murati joined [Leap Motion](#), a startup building hand- and finger-tracking motion sensors for PCs, as VP of product and engineering. Murati wanted to make the experience of interacting with a computer "as intuitive as playing with a ball," she [told](#) Fast Company in an interview. But she soon realized that the tech, which relied on a VR headset, was too early.

As OpenAI's CTO, Murati developed a bit of a reputation for making controversial pronouncements.

She once vaguely [claimed](#) in an interview that OpenAI's AI would achieve "Ph.D.-level" intelligence. And in June, Murati raised eyebrows when she [suggested](#) that AI would replace creative jobs that "shouldn't have been there in the first place."

"Some creative jobs maybe will go away, but maybe they shouldn't have been there in the first place if the content that comes out of it is not very high

quality,” Murati said in an onstage interview at The Wall Street Journal’s WSJ Tech Live Conference. “I really believe that using it as a tool for education [and] creativity will expand our intelligence and creativity and imagination.”

Murati is the latest high-level exec to depart OpenAI in recent months. Sutskever and former safety leader [Jan Leike](#) announced their departures in May, and co-founder [John Schulman](#) said last month that he was leaving to join rival Anthropic. Meanwhile, OpenAI’s president, Greg Brockman, is on extended leave through the end of the year.

Murati’s decision to step down comes as OpenAI is said to be [pursuing a funding round](#) that would value the company at over \$150 billion.

Microsoft, Nvidia, Apple, and Thrive Capital are reportedly in talks to invest; the round could end up being as large as \$6.5 billion, per Bloomberg and [others](#).

OpenAI desperately needs the money. [According](#) to The Information, the company has spent approximately \$7 billion on model training and \$1.5 billion on staffing. At one point in time, ChatGPT alone was said to be [costing](#) OpenAI around \$700,000 a day to run; Altman has said that training the company’s once-flagship [GPT-4](#) model cost over \$100 million.

Topics: [AI](#) [Mira Murati](#) [OpenAI](#)



Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter |

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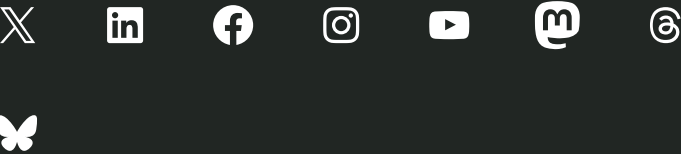


Kyle Wiggers

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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch’s AI Editor until June 2025.
His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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